blessings of the Chief Minister. Karunakaran resigned as the Chief Minister in 16 March 1995, paving way for A K Antony.

Years later, Cherian Philip, a Youth Congress leader and a foot soldier of the Antony camp, would confess about Chandy's machinations that resulted in the suspension of an upright IPS officer.

Seventeen years later, when the Kerala high court in 2012 directed the state government to pay Rs 10 lakhs to me as an interim compensation, the episode would return to haunt both Antony and Chandy. The Karunakaran family would then demand an investigation into the 'political conspiracy behind the case and action against three officers of the Kerala Police who the CBI found to have fabricated the case. Even today, Chandy squirms in his chair when asked about the ISRO spy case. At a press conference in July 2016, Chandy was at pains trying to argue that Karunakaran's ouster in 1995 had nothing to do with the ISRO spy case, and that it was because of a difference of opinion over the selection of a Rajya Sabha candidate.

MARIAM GETS A REPRIEVE, CBI SAYS SPY CASE IS FALSE

The two Maldivian women were still in jail, as the government slapped another case of national security. When a Chief Judicial Magistrate on 14 November 1995, acquitted Mariam Rasheeda in the case of overstaying; the genesis of it all, the very foundation of the spy story was shaken.

The case in which Mariam was charged under the Foreigners Act, 1946, stated that she was staying in India beyond the ninety days that the rules permitted. Maldivians were exempted from the requirement of visa, if the stay did not exceed ninety days. For Mariam, who was on her third visit since 2 June 1994, the deadline was 14 October 1994.

According to the chargesheet, on 20 October 1994, city special branch inspector S Vijayan, while on a routine inspection of lodgings where foreigners were staying, came across details of Mariam, who was staying in Hotel Samrat, Trivandrum.